Project: Worked examples
Title: Column buckling (Perry–Robertson)
Status: DRAFT Author: TempestOS (2026-10-23) Checker: — (—) Issued: —

1. Scope and method

Compressive strength and resistance of a pin-ended strut of a given effective length, from Euler's critical stress reduced for initial imperfection by the Perry–Robertson formula, with the Robertson constant chosen by strut curve; utilisation against an applied axial load.
r = √(I/A); λ = L_E/r. p_E = π²E/λ²; P_E = p_E·A. λ_0 = 0.2·√(π²E/p_y). η = max(0.001·a·(λ − λ_0), 0). φ = (p_y + (η + 1)·p_E)/2. p_c = p_E·p_y/(φ + √(φ² − p_E·p_y)); P_c = p_c·A; u = P/P_c. Robertson constant a = 2.0, 3.5, 5.5, 8.0 for curves a–d.
Ref: BS 5950-1:2000 Annex C — Compressive strength (Perry strut formula)
Ref: BS 5950-1:2000 4.7.3.2 — Maximum slenderness
Ref: BS 5950-1:2000 Table 23 — Allocation of strut curve

2. Inputs

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
L_E	Effective length	1.5	m	drawing: DRG-ST-411 rev A	0.1 … 50 m
A	Cross-section area	1200	mm^2	spec: SPEC-ST-02 section schedule	10 … 1000000 mm^2
I	Second moment of area about the weaker axis	12	cm^4	spec: SPEC-ST-02 section schedule	0.01 … 10000000 cm^4
E	Modulus of elasticity	205	GPa	spec: BS 5950-1 3.1.3: E = 205 GPa	50 … 450 GPa
p_y	Design strength (yield)	355	MPa	spec: SPEC-ST-02: S355	100 … 1000 MPa
curve	Strut curve (selects the Robertson constant)	b		spec: BS 5950-1 Table 23: hot-finished tube, curve b	any
P	Applied axial load	100	kN	assumption: Factored brace force	0 … 100000 kN

3. Assumptions

A1. Pin-ended, prismatic strut under axial load only; buckling about the axis of the given second moment. (Effective length carries the end restraint.)
A2. Initial imperfection represented by the Perry factor η = 0.001·a·(λ − λ_0), with a from the strut curve. (Robertson's fit to strut tests.)
A3. P (Applied axial load) is taken as 100 kN. (Factored brace force)

4. Working

`[8] α_R = 3.5` BS 5950-1 Annex C
`= 3.5`
Robertson constant for strut curve b

[9] r = sqrt(I / A)
= sqrt(12 cm⁴ / 1200 mm²)
= 10 mm
Radius of gyration
[10] lambda = L_E / r
= 1.5 m / 10 mm
= 150
Slenderness
[11] p_E = pi^2 * E / lambda^2 BS 5950-1 Annex C
= π^2 × 205 GPa / 150^2
= 89.923 MPa
Euler critical stress
[12] P_E = p_E * A
= 89.923 MPa × 1200 mm²
= 107.91 kN
Euler critical load
[13] lambda_0 = 0.2 * sqrt(pi^2 * E / p_y) BS 5950-1 Annex C
= 0.2 × sqrt(π^2 × 205 GPa / 355 MPa)
= 15.099
Limiting slenderness
[14] eta = max(0.001 * a_R * (lambda - lambda_0), 0) BS 5950-1 Annex C
= max(0.001 × 3.5 × (150 - 15.099), 0)
= 0.47215
Perry factor (initial imperfection)
[15] phi = (p_y + (eta + 1) * p_E) / 2
= (355 MPa + (0.47215 + 1) × 89.923 MPa) / 2
= 243.69 MPa
Perry–Robertson φ
[16] p_c = p_E * p_y / (phi + sqrt(phi^2 - p_E * p_y)) BS 5950-1 Annex C
= 89.923 MPa × 355 MPa / (243.69 MPa + sqrt((243.69 MPa)^2 - 89.923 MPa × 355 MPa))
= 77.973 MPa
Compressive strength
[17] P_c = p_c * A
= 77.973 MPa × 1200 mm²
= 93.567 kN
Compression resistance
[18] u = P / P_c
= 100 kN / 93.567 kN
= 1.0687
Utilisation

5. Results

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
r	10 mm	Radius of gyration
lambda	150	Slenderness
p_E	89.923 MPa	Euler stress
P_E	107.91 kN	Euler load
lambda_0	15.099	Limiting slenderness
eta	0.47215	Perry factor
p_c	77.973 MPa	Compressive strength

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
P_c	93.567 kN	Compression resistance
u	1.0687	Utilisation

6. Checks (governing first)

RESULT	CHECK	DEMAND	CAPACITY	UTILISATION	REF
FAIL	Axial load against compression resistance	u = 1.0687	u ≤ 1	1.07	BS 5950-1 Annex C

7. Applicability

No warnings.

8. Verification

Template struct.column-buckling@1.0.0 Content hash 8f5b0ac422d1fc8b Engine calc-engine/1.0.0
Known-answer cases passed 3/3 Test run 2026-10-23 12:00 UTC TempestOS 0.26.0